efficiency, he was given charge of much of the Punjab, although he was only nineteen years old.[18] In the years that followed, as Shah Zaman marched and counter-marched trying to maintain his fracturing empire, it was Ranjit Singh who would slowly prise the lucrative eastern provinces of the Durrani Empire from his former overlord and take his place as the dominant power in the Punjab.

'The Afghans of Khurasan have an age-old reputation,' wrote Mirza 'Ata Mohammad, one of the most perceptive writers of Shah Shuja's age, 'that wherever the lamp of power burns brightly, there like moths they swarm; and wherever the tablecloth of plenty is spread, there like flies they gather.'[19] The reverse was also true. As Zaman retreated, thwarted from plundering India and hemmed in by the Sikhs, British and Persians, his authority waned and one by one his nobles, his extended family and finally even his half-brothers rebelled against him.

The end of Shah Zaman's rule came during the icy winter of 1800, when the Kabulis finally refused to open the city gates to their luckless king. Instead, one cold winter's night, with the falling snow soft on his lashes, he took shelter from the gathering blizzard in a fortress between Jalalabad and the Khyber. That night, he was imprisoned by his Shinwari hosts, who locked the gates, murdered his bodyguard and later blinded him with a hot needle: 'The point', wrote Mirza 'Ata, 'quickly spilled the wine of his sight from the cup of his eyes.'[20]

The proud and bookish Prince Shuja was only fourteen years old when his elder brother was blinded and deposed. Shuja was Shah Zaman's 'constant companion at all times' and, in the coup d'état that followed, troops were sent out to arrest him. But he eluded the search parties and with a few companions wandered on unmarked tracks from the poplars and holly oaks of the valleys to the crystalline snows of the high passes, cresting the kerfs and shelves of the mountains, sleeping rough and biding his time. He was an intelligent, gentle and literate teenager, who abhorred the violence spiralling around him, and in adversity sought solace in poetry. 'Lose no hope when faced with hardships,' he wrote at this time, while moving from mountain village to mountain village, protected by loyal tribesmen. 'Black clouds soon give way to clear rain.'[21]

Like Babur, the first Mughal Emperor, Shah Shuja crafted a beautifully written autobiography where he talks of his days as a homeless wanderer on the snow-slopes of the Safed Koh, padding around the silent shores of high-